

Concede AND RULE

The UPA has negotiated with friends and compromised with enemies to survive a year of missed opportunities. Now it should get down to business.

| By Priya Sahgal |

You could call it distilled wisdom. A few hours before the crucial Cut Motion, Pranab Mukherjee, the grand old man of the Congress, met ace strategist Ahmed Patel and Union ministers Prithviraj Chavan and Pawan Bansal. Ever cautious, Mukherjee told the trio: "I have often noticed that it's not the planned moves but the accidents that count." Clearly, Mukherjee didn't want anything to be left to chance. That evening there were no accidents, at least none that was unplanned. The Government won the day with 289 votes against the 201 bagged by the Opposition. Yes the BJP is still wondering whether Shibu Soren's vote in favour of the UPA was an accident, but even that pink slip was well planned.

The victory, though well executed, reveals the fragility embedded in the arithmetic of the UPA. The Congress with 207 MPs, its largest in nearly two decades, was expected to push through critical reforms and get down to the serious business of governance. It should have been able to manage the coalition well enough, not find itself vulnerable to threats. In its first tenure, the UPA faced one serious challenge—but that was in its fourth year. In its second tenure, the socialist collective finds itself buffeted by derision within the coalition and division within its own ranks. A few days shy of its first anniversary or the sixth year in power, the Manmohan Singh regime would have liked to ring in the birthday with a platter of successful leg-

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